

major loss of face for Gadkari. Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Arun Jaitley announced, "the party decided that enough is enough," even as Gadkari was away holidaying in Europe. Though Jaitley took pains to claim that it was a unanimous decision, what preceded was anything but unanimous. Chairman of BJP's parliamentary board L.K. Advani and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Sushma Swaraj had been opposed to leading a government in Jharkhand. They were also not happy with the farcical exchanges between the BJP and the JMM, played out in full media glare.

However, Gadkari decided to throw his hat in the ring despite that. He had the blessings of the RSS, some say. That explains his choice of the team he sent for negotiations with JMM. His predecessor Rajnath Singh and party general secretary Ananth Kumar were given the responsibility of dealing with the devious Soren in his absence. A Gadkari supporter in the party tried to justify the efforts at government formation in Jharkhand. "More than 30 per cent of the state population has been converted to Christianity. The BJP was trying to prevent the formation of a government with Congress support because that would mean increase in conversions," was the excuse offered by a party leader. Whatever may have been his calculations, the Jharkhand fiasco has left Gadkari red-faced. "We could have handled it better," admits one of his close associates. The BJP has come out of the Jharkhand fiasco appearing power-hungry and wanting to form a government at any cost. It lost the chance of taking a high moral ground.

Having failed his first real test of Jharkhand, Gadkari's next major challenge are the Assembly elections in Bihar later this year. His lack of self-assurance in taking major decisions was also reflected in the delay in appointing presidents of state units, including Bihar. In fact, due to this dilly-dallying, Ananth Kumar was initially reluctant to take charge of Bihar before the elections. Gadkari had then

decided to make general secretary Dharmendra Pradhan as the state in-charge with secretary Bhupendra Yadav as co-in charge. However, once things looked settled in Bihar with C.P. Thakur appointed president of the state unit, Kumar used his influence with Gadkari, saying he was willing to become the election in-charge. There are also whispers within the party that leaders like Kumar and Jaitley wield substantial influence in decision-making. Jaitley is close to Gadkari's old

VIKRAM SHARMA/www.indiatodayimages.com



BJP LEADERS AT THE DELHI RALLY ON PRICE RISE (TOP) AND SHIBU SOREN WITH ARJUN MUNDA (LEFT)



ANAND SEN

People who still matter Even as senior leader L.K. Advani

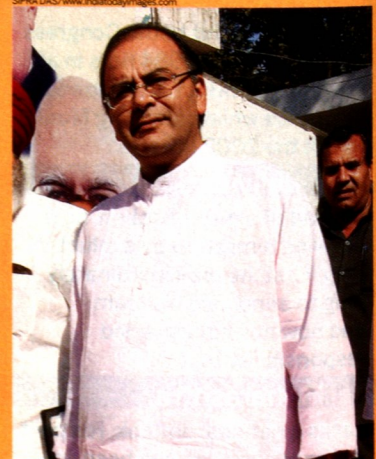
RAVISH SAHANI/www.indiatodayimages.com



Rajnath Singh

Being close to RSS, he is Gadkari's natural ally. Was chosen along with Kumar to negotiate with the JMM.

SIPRA DAS/www.indiatodayimages.com



Arun Jaitley

He continues to wield influence in the party as Gadkari has allowed him a say in some decisions.